

Naturally enough, it is the young businessman who, through inexperience or immaturity, usually makes the most errors. Some of his blunders are inadvertent, not very serious and entirely understandable and excusable. Other errors are the results of inadequate training or insufficient or faulty understanding of business in general or of his own business in particular. Yet other blunders stem from out-and-out inaptitude or incompetence—but these, needless to say, soon prove fatal to any business career.

The examples I've cited from personal experience serve to illustrate three of the major categories of mistakes I've found are most commonly and most often made by businessmen, especially when they are relatively inexperienced and unseasoned.

The first of these is the failure—or the inability—to distinguish between what is fact and what is opinion. Though it may be carefully considered and based on fact, opinion nonetheless remains opinion—and it is very seldom infallible. Opinion is never better than the information on which it is based, the qualifications of the person voicing it and his ability to correctly interpret the information at his disposal. Businessmen are sometimes inclined to read or hear opinions and accept them as facts upon which to base their plans or make their decisions without further investigation or study. Such was the error I made when I sold my lease on the Yale Pool property. Although I was well aware that in those days geology was far from being

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the most exact of sciences, I blindly accepted the word—the opinion—of the geologist who inspected the property. I did not take the time nor the trouble to consult anyone else to obtain a "cross-reading" on the single "expert's" judgment. I cannot blame the geologist for making a wrong recommendation. I can blame only myself for accepting it without question.

The predilection for accepting opinion or even rumor as fact is a fairly familiar and widespread human failing. Anyone harboring doubts on this score need only reflect on how often he has heard individuals repeat as fact the opinionated statements they read in highly biased newspaper editorials,